

The background of the page is a light gray illustration of a library with several rows of bookshelves. On the shelves are various books of different heights and widths. Scattered throughout the library are several black graduation caps (mortarboards) with yellow tassels. One cap is prominently featured on the left side, tilted upwards. Another is on the right side, tilted downwards. A third is in the center, tilted upwards. A fourth is on the bottom left, tilted downwards. A fifth is on the bottom right, tilted downwards. The overall style is clean and modern.

Global convention on the Recognition of Higher Education Qualifications - A Perspective from the Student Community.

2021 |

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1.0 FOREWORD

1.1 AASU

The Global Recognition Convention, indeed, provides an opportunity for lifelong learning for all, including, migrant students. This convention offers the opportunity to turn around the state of education globally in addressing the major challenges and opportunities that exist for mobile academics.

As student unions spread out across the world, we have been incredibly involved in demanding the rights of all young people to quality education without any form of discrimination. We believe strongly in the fair treatment of all students and that all young people deserve to be given an equal chance at life through the opportunity that education provides.

Students constitute the majority of the higher education community as compared to faculty, administrative and support staff. Therefore, while the success of every higher education institution may depend on the strength and quality of its administrative and teaching staff, incorporating and considering the voices of the student body is key to the survival of any higher education institution. Also, in past times, students have been instrumental in the success of higher education institutions, and even in building very resilient educational systems for all. Hence, students and student unions have become very critical stakeholders in the educational space.

I am delighted to join hands with my colleagues from the Global Student Forum, Commonwealth Student Association, European Students Union and Latin American and Caribbean Continental Organization of Students to put together this report on the Global Recognition Convention.

We look forward to having the recommendations in this report taken into consideration for further actions as well as the Student-led Ratification Campaign – which you will find more about in this document.

The All-Africa Students Union, working hand-in-hand with our global friends, are certainly keen on engaging more stakeholders in this regard. I hope you find this report useful. Thank you.



Yours in the service of Students;
Peter Kwasi Kodjie
Secretary-General
All-Africa Students Union



1.2 GSF

While the demand for higher education systems with a greater international outlook is voiced prominently by decision makers and competent national authorities all over the globe, little has been done in order to reduce the barriers that keep students and academic staff from truly being mobile. Fair and uncomplicated recognition of educational qualifications acquired abroad is crucial in order to facilitate a worldwide circulation of knowledge that will improve society at large. The Global Recognition Convention can achieve exactly this, if it is ratified by enough countries. It could bring the change that so many learners worldwide are waiting for.

A non-discriminatory and transparent international system to assess educational qualifications will not only bring us closer together as a global academic community, but will also enhance the quality of higher education institutions through a more diverse approach to teaching, research and learning. The Global Student Forum fully supports this aim and therefore engages in this report and the student-led campaign which will follow because we firmly believe that reducing access barriers to higher education between countries results in the free movement of bright minds that enrich foreign educational systems with new perspectives and different approaches to academia.

In the spirit of solidarity and global cooperation between students and their movements, we stand together and demand from decision makers to break the chains that keep learners from reaching their full potential. This potential can be unlocked if countries ratify the convention and therefore enable a new generation of students to truly experience academic mobility on a global scale, like it was never seen before. This is the promise of the Convention and we will do our part to make it a reality.



Sincerely yours,
Sebastian Berger
Executive Director
Global Student Forum



1.3 OCLAE

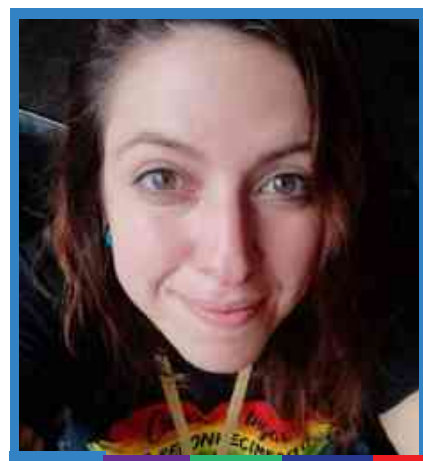
For education in Latin America, initiatives to integrate the countries' educational policies are essential. Vast and diverse, our region is marked by deep inequalities that condition the lives of students and the functioning of universities. It is common, for example, for students to migrate in search of an opportunity to pursue higher education due to the high costs and difficulty of access to higher education in their countries of origin. There is also a considerable flow of professionals who leave one country to work professionally in another, a reality that shows that standardizing a policy for the recognition and validation of diplomas is an imperative need.

For OCLAE, which represents 23 countries and more than 40 student organizations, it is a valuable experience to be able to take students' contributions to the Global convention on the Recognition of Higher Education Qualifications with the aim of establishing an education without borders and strengthening ties between the student community not only on our continent but around the world. Together with organizations from other continents, thinking about a global solution to this reality is an advance that needs to be celebrated for its great potential to expand access to higher education in the world and intensify cooperation between educational institutions worldwide.

Equally important is to strengthen scientific cooperation in the region to guarantee sovereign, articulate and sustainable regional development. The role of education for the development of science and technology capable of improving the lives of the population and promoting the economic, social and cultural development of our countries is well known. For universities to connect more and more to the different realities and serve for their transformation is essential, and that is why we join with students from all over the world for this initiative.



Bia Lopez
Executive Secretary
Latin American and Caribbean Continental
Organization of Students



1.4 Commonwealth Students Association

The Commonwealth Students' Association (CSA) welcomes the Global convention on the Recognition of Qualifications concerning Higher education adopted by UNESCO's General Conference in 2019. This is a significant milestone in adapting to a highly globalized world with rapidly increasing mobility of students across the regions. When countries make a commitment to adopting a standard framework to recognize qualifications of students in higher education transnationally, we will finally progress towards fair, equitable and inclusive access to education. These values are highly aligned with the Commonwealth's charter of providing equitable access to high quality education and meeting the needs of small and/or vulnerable states.

Students migrate to foreign countries, predominantly to the West, for hopes of a more prosperous future, cultural exchange, expanded knowledge acquisition or for seeking refuge from volatile conditions in their home countries. Notwithstanding their purpose, students should have access to a clear and fair system that will recognize their local qualifications which is currently missing for many as they are bombarded by expensive language or aptitude tests to qualify for foreign universities, creating an environment of exclusion and discrimination. Given the nature of trans-national collaboration in research and development and global co-creation of knowledge, this is a long awaited legally binding treaty on higher education. It will also be an ode to the call for decolonizing education around the world, creating space for inclusion of knowledge from the Global South and levelling the playing field for learners and knowledge creators outside the Global North. In 2015, the Virtual University for Small State of the Commonwealth (VUSS) launched a Transnational Qualifications Framework for small states within the Commonwealth after recognizing a gap. This framework provides a reference system, which links national qualifications systems across small states. The guidelines in the framework enables the alignment of qualifications with the aim of enhancing cross national mobility for education and employment.

The CSA together with the Commonwealth fully supports the implementation of a global recognition framework and we eagerly look forward to the improved lives of students and young people, the social and economic progression, cultural exchange as well as a global distribution of knowledge.



Yours sincerely,
Dr Musarrat Maisha Reza
Chairperson, Commonwealth Students'
Association
University of Exeter, UK



1.4 ESU

Student federations all over the world have grown tired of the insufficient attention given towards enabling education institutions to be more open to diverse groups of students. As the COVID-19 pandemic and climate crisis continue to wreak havoc, it is crystal clear to us that we will not recover the economic and environmental well-being of our society if barriers for non-traditional students wishing to access education to gain new knowledge and skills persist.

The European Students' Union firmly supports the call for global convergence efforts in higher education and sees the ratification of the Global Recognition Convention as the first and foremost enabler of the right to access high quality and sustainable lifelong learning for all as well as mobility and internationalization.

Strategic commitment towards implementing the GRC requires public authorities and institutional leaders to engage in continuous policy dialogue in order to reach the most reasonable reconciliation of a diversity of stakeholders' perspectives. Tensions between global convergence and national diversities are expected, especially now during times of bad political governance and economic fallout. It is therefore that hand in hand with the ratification process, comparative research is crucial to achieve a better understanding of the concept of convergence in higher education and its connection with national development, putting focus on the differences between countries to establish mechanisms of unification.

Through this publication, we take a look back at and learn from the intergovernmental processes that led to the harmonization of higher education in Europe at the turn of the millennium. Two decades on, European higher education still consists of national and heterogeneous higher education systems, the challenge now is that some of them are more 'globalized' than others. Therefore, alongside ratification and research, it is equally important to foster more sustainable organization models for our education systems and our institutions through financial and capacity building resources that incentivize the development of these models. Finally, and possibly the most contentious debate for our generation, is ensuring that the independence and autonomy of academia to serve the public good is not stripped away. May we not forget that while it is the public's responsibility to ensure our education institutions are accountable to the needs of their wider communities, it is first and foremost a public responsibility to ensure that education is adequately funded to meet these needs.



Martina Darmanin
President
European Students Union

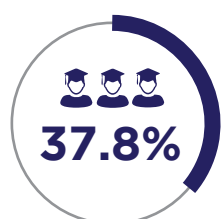


2.0 EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

One major factor in the late 20th century was that humankind entered into an accelerated process of multidimensional changes within the fields of economy, finance, science and technology, communications, education, culture, and politics. This new context was characterised by a relationship of increasing interdependence and competitiveness between nations, changing the traditional motive of international relations to some extent. No country was excluded from this phenomenon. However, although the processes of globalisation and modernisation developed simultaneously throughout the planet, this development, to a considerable extent, has been generated in an unequal, divergent, and contradictory manner. Due to the rapid globalisation of the world's economy, education has been one of the sectors that has undergone significant changes, not only concerning how pedagogy is carried out but also concerning the individuals (i.e. graduates, researchers) these universities churn out.

Consequently, the international dimension of higher education institutions has now become a crucial educational opportunity to empower people with a strategic perspective and sufficient preparation to function and live in a globalized environment. Higher education internationalization represents an educational reform whose values are the driving force behind the political, ethical and intercultural essence of the social relationships that promote the development of a critical citizenry through cultivating global knowledge and perspective among graduates of universities.

The importance of higher education internationalization has pushed into force the need for recognition schemes not only at the regional levels but also at the global level.



Available data by Eurostat shows that more than one third (37.8 %) of international students who conducted tertiary studies in the European Union in 2017 were from Europe



30.1 % were from Asia,



13.0 % were from Africa.

As is the case for all students, not just those from abroad, the highest shares of these students were either enrolled in a bachelor's degree (45.6 %) or a master's degree (41.9 %), while 9.3 % were studying for doctoral degrees and 3.1 % followed short-cycle tertiary courses . With growing statistics concerning people on the move, education has been one of the central themes influencing policy directions, including jobs, qualifications, and skills.

The survival of human beings largely depends on their abilities to work and make a livelihood for themselves and their families. Education provides people with the opportunity to pick up relevant skills, qualifications, and knowledge to create jobs or be employed and become active participants of nation-building.



In November 2019, the Global convention on the Recognition of Qualifications concerning Higher education was adopted by UNESCO's General Conference, making it the first legally binding United Nations treaty on higher education. The convention, among other things, seeks to provide immense support for academic mobility. The convention will likely have an impact on diverse sectors especially in the future of work and the education of refugees or migrants. It is evident that students continue to be on the move for diverse causes. Some move for deliberate reasons, while others are forced to leave their home countries or countries of residence due to the unbearable circumstances on site. Regardless of the challenges which students face when studying abroad, for many this option never presents due to circumstances that prevent trans-national mobility. It has been a continuous challenge for students to have their prior academic qualifications recognised in other countries. In some cases, students are being asked to pay horrendous sums of money to write complementary exams taken by foreign higher education institutions before they are considered to be granted admission in their educational institution of choice.

The Global convention seeks to eliminate some of these barriers by streamlining recognition systems at the global level. It is the first of its kind and will undoubtedly change the face of higher education and likely lead to an increase in enrolment of international students worldwide. This report captures the involvement of regional student unions in the design and implementation of regional recognition conventions. It also highlights the existing conventions at the regional levels and how they will facilitate recognition processes together with the newly adopted Global Recognition Convention.

The global convention requires 20 countries to ratify it before it can come into full force. The regional student unions involved in the publication of this report intend to put together a "Student-led Global Ratification Campaign" together with other partners. The campaign aims to be a major global endeavor involving over 196 student unions from 118 countries all geared towards creating a better opportunity for all students.

This report captures and provides perspectives of student organisations on the Global Recognition Convention, while putting forward recommendations and solutions that will aid in the implementation and ratification of the convention. The report is shared with partners and relevant stakeholders in the spirit of the promotion of lifelong learning and access to equitable quality education for all.



3.0 INTRODUCTION

Education is and must be recognised as a fundamental human right that has the potential to drive change and to increase the chances of attaining diverse developmental agendas. We can truly achieve all other sustainable development goals – empower women and girls, fight climate change, reduce inequalities and poverty – if we have a well-educated citizenry. Great education systems can also aid migrants and refugees to adjust appropriately and continue with their lives.

With growing statistics concerning people on the move, education has been one of the central themes influencing policy directions, including jobs, qualifications, and skills. Education provides people with the opportunity to pick up relevant skills, qualifications, and knowledge to create jobs or be employed and become active participants of nation-building.

The mismatch between skills qualifications in some countries and skills recognition in others leaves so much wasted talent, resulting in frustration and lack of opportunities. The disparities in country qualifications and recognition systems make it difficult for individuals to further their studies, engage in research activities, or explore employment opportunities. A global commitment to develop standards and guidelines for the mutual recognition of foreign qualifications and non-formally acquired skills, work on the comparability of national qualifications frameworks, involvement of the private sector, extension of internship programmes and mentoring, as well as the provision of language-specific training could turn thousands, if not millions, of people's lives around. The Global convention on the Recognition of Higher Education Qualifications provides an opportunity to achieve these outcomes.

This report captures and provides perspectives of student organisations on the Global Recognition Convention, while putting forward recommendations and solutions that will aid in the implementation and ratification of the convention. The report is shared with partners and relevant stakeholders in the spirit of the promotion of lifelong learning and access to equitable quality education for all.

Europe's Lisbon Recognition Convention is one of the leading examples of regional efforts towards the harmonisation of higher education systems taking place in every corner of the world. In Africa, such a convention and associated efforts have been around for decades, although more coordinated activities are only recent phenomena. The Arusha Convention, which puts in place a framework for the recognition of academic qualifications throughout the African continent, is such an example. It was adopted on 5th of December 1981 and has recently been revised into the Addis Ababa Convention. However, nearly five years after its adoption and despite the many benefits it offers, only 12 out of 55 African countries have ratified it.

This joint publication, which involves the All-Africa Students Union, European Students Union, Commonwealth Students Association and OCLAE, tries to explore the Global convention from the student perspective while considering the existing frameworks in the continents which the student unions represent. It furthermore aims to explain in simple terms what recognition means for education and what difference the Global convention would make on other sectors such as brain circulation, global trade, intercultural exchanges, rights and interests of students, as well as skills and competencies. This report relies on anecdotal evidence and collected data from pre-existing documents.

Primary data was collected to aid in the preparation of this report. Over 60 student leaders, from different parts of the world, were consulted to provide answers to questions focused on how student leaders perceive the global recognition convention and what impacts it will have on sectors such as intercultural exchanges, global trade, rights of students, brain circulation and skills and competencies. The GCRHEQ survey received the highest number of respondents from the Asian continent, summing 75% of the total respondents. Respondents were from Pakistan, India, Bangladesh, Malaysia, Indonesia, Brunei, Myanmar, Laos, Philippines, Vietnam, and Laos, representing different organizations. However, majority of the respondents (44.1%) were from Pakistan. 70.6% of the respondents were male whereas 29.4% were female, indicating a clear absence of non-binary respondents.

3.1 Recognition of Education Qualifications and Mobility Schemes

Globalisation has, to a considerable extent, re-shaped the approaches to higher education and compelled governments and intergovernmental bodies to agree on and work towards the achievement of common values and development agendas. Higher education Institutions (HEIs) around the world are thus required to actively adjust themselves to the shifting dynamics of global education which move towards the trends of open access for public scrutiny, especially concerning their quality, efficiency, and effectiveness in delivering higher education. As migration trends continuously increase around the world, the realization of non-discriminatory access to quality education for all requires urgent attention and support.

Following the aim of creating a more sustainable world, educational systems need to adapt and become more inclusive, tolerant, and applicable to diverse contexts. The recognition of educational qualifications and the establishment of resilient mobility schemes help to attain these goals. However, it should be noted that solely having strong recognition systems in place will not be enough to promote students and academic mobility. Other issues; in particular, foreign language proficiency and adequate financial support, also need to be addressed if students and staff mobility are to increase significantly.

Recognition of educational qualifications has to do with the acceptance and acknowledgment of the validity or credibility of foreign qualifications. It is an opportunity to transfer prior learning in one country of study to another country where a mobile individual is seeking to pursue an academic programme or profession. Recognition of educational qualifications and mobility schemes have become more relevant, especially in times where more people are mobile than ever before.

The number of international migrants globally reached an estimated 272 million in 2019, an increase of 51 million since 2010. Currently, international migrants comprise 3.5 per cent of the global population, compared to 2.8 per cent in the year 2000, according to new estimates released by the United Nations. The growing number of migrants could be attributed to a need to pursue new working or educational opportunities, the need to flee from war zones, political persecution and environmental disasters among others. In any of these cases, the interest to continuously learn and acquire new and relevant skills may always be applicable.

Mobility schemes are geared towards facilitating the free, orderly, and safe movement of persons from one country to another. More than 2.5 million students pursue higher education outside their region – a number that is likely to grow in the coming years, according to UNESCO's estimates.

With a globalised economy that relies on technical innovations and competitive use of knowledge by skilled individuals, higher education is seen as essential for a country's economic growth and enhancement in the standard of living. Accessible and fair recognition procedures are crucial when it comes to promoting mobility for all.

UNESCO, together with its development partners, has been at the forefront of putting in measures to ensure the delivery of inclusive, accessible, and quality higher education. Efforts to create a global convention on recognition eventually resulted in six regional recognition conventions (for Latin America and the Caribbean, the Mediterranean, the Arab States, Europe, Africa, and the Asia-Pacific regions) in the 1970s and 1980s, which established a unique legal framework for allowing the recognition of qualifications in higher education between State Parties at a regional level. In 1993, a UNESCO Recommendation on the topic was adopted after further attempts for a global convention did not succeed. For this report, we will be taking a look at regional recognition and mobility schemes in Latin America and the Caribbean, Africa, and Europe.

All respondents from Africa were members or leaders in their respective national student unions. 25% of these respondents were females and 75% were males. When asked whether or not they are familiar with any recognition or mobility scheme, most of the African student leaders admitted that they were not aware but however are interested in learning more about it. They also indicated the will to be taken through workshops that will enable meaningful engagement in the future. However, all of the respondents were able to share thoughts about their country's National Qualifications Framework and to which extent it had been developed even though some of the information provided was not very accurate when it comes to the current status of their NQF. From the European perspective, in 6 of the respondents' countries, the National Qualifications Framework is fully developed or approved. Moreover, the framework is in the development/consultation phase in the Czech Republic while early consultations are taking place in Russia. If the NQF is fully developed, it mostly encompasses all sectors (5 out of 6), whereas the frameworks under development currently solely aim at higher education sector. 7 out of 9 are aware of the local recognition conventions, mostly thanks to exposure on educational conferences and QA workshops or directly via channels of ESU.

Nevertheless, there seems to be a room for improvement in the engagement of student representatives in the design and implementation of regional recognition conventions. Out of 9 respondents, only 1 stated that they were somehow involved by the authorities in the process, in this case in the form of consultation on the topic. In response to the question about the National Qualifications Framework, from respondents in Asia, and its development stage in the respondents' respective countries, 11.8% mentioned that they are not aware of it, 17.6% said it is not in place in their countries, 8.8% said it is in an early thinking stage while 23.5% stated that it is in its development or consultation stage, 17.6% affirmed that an NQF it is in place, being operated and reviewed for some time. 20.6% reported that and NQF is in place as fully developed and approved as legal act. When asked about how comprehensive the NQF is in their country, 20.6% shared they are not certain, 5.9% reported it is for schooling only, 47.1% stated it applies for higher education only, and 26.5% shared it is applicable in all sectors.

The student leaders also shared their aspirations in regards to what a recognition convention could achieve, which can be summed up as providing a “fair” and “equal” access to higher education while enhancing its “quality” everywhere. Findings show that, while many student leaders do not possess adequate knowledge on recognition conventions, some expressed their view on them as a form of agreement, rule, norms, university accreditations etc. A few also think that it is a recognition system by the United Nations member states. Clearly, there is a lack of proper knowledge among the respondents around GCRHEQ.

3.2 What is Recognition, and why is it important?

UNESCO has defined recognition as “a formal acknowledgment by a competent recognition authority of the validity and academic level of foreign education qualification, of partial studies, or prior learning to provide an applicant with outcomes including, but not limited to” :

- (a) the right to apply for admission to higher education; and
- (b) the possibility to seek employment opportunities

Recognition is a system that can be put in place to ensure that prior learning anywhere is applicable elsewhere with similar considerations that will remove the limitations to a learner’s further studies. Recognition is essential in promoting the ethos of globalisation and the need to harmonise the world systems to foster more safe and orderly migration.

Having a formalised and globally accepted recognition scheme offers learners the opportunity to pursue their academic goals from any part of the world. It also promotes the commitments of lifelong learning for all. Recognition has become more critical now more than ever considering the significant improvements in access to basic and secondary education, an increase in students crossing borders to pursue higher education, a desire for more mobility within economic regions, the changing nature of the global economy, and the increase in trade agreements that incorporate provisions on recognition – for example, better functioning recognition schemes would help to promote the tenets of Free Trade Areas especially in the distribution of skills/brain circulation.

Ensuring migrants’ education is key to attaining all other developmental goals as it provides an opportunity to attract and maintain relevant skills and knowledge. Ignoring the education of migrants squanders a great deal of human potential. Sometimes simple paperwork, lack of data, or bureaucratic and uncoordinated systems are to be held responsible for many people falling through administrative cracks, neglecting the added value, that investing in the education of highly talented and driven migrants and refugees can boost development and economic growth, not only in the host countries but also in the countries of origin.

3.3 How does recognition affect mobility?

Mobility can be explained as the movement of persons from one geographical location to another (physical mobility) or from one level of society to another (social mobility). Mobility is an essential and recurrent aspect of the human race. It provides an opportunity for new experiences and an exchange of skills, knowledge, and competencies. When people move to study, to work, or to find a new place of habitation, they come with prior experiences and qualifications. Hence, they can easily carry on with their goals or aspirations if their prior learning experiences or skills are acknowledged.

The world is on the move: in 2013, an estimated 232 million people migrated internationally. Labour demands, economic crises, urbanisation, entrenched poverty, political instability, development projects, and conflict continue to fuel the global movement of peoples. Providing essential social, health, and educational services for migrant populations has become a pressing concern in all regions of the world.

Learners and educators constitute quite a large number of the migrant population. Hence, for this report, we will look at mobility from the perspective of students, staff, and academic mobility. Not to say that recognition could solely facilitate the pursuance of educational goals. Recognition, has the potential of affecting personal mobility geared towards finding new career paths, influencing trade and investments, among others.

Generally, students and staff mobility can lead to the formation of complex international groups which become a unique and diverse social milieu, having a positive impact on the host higher education institution. Academic mobility refers to the movement from one academic institution to another, which may be in the same country. Thus, students and staff can return to their universities to share new experiences, as well as best practices that enhance the higher education systems in their countries of origin.

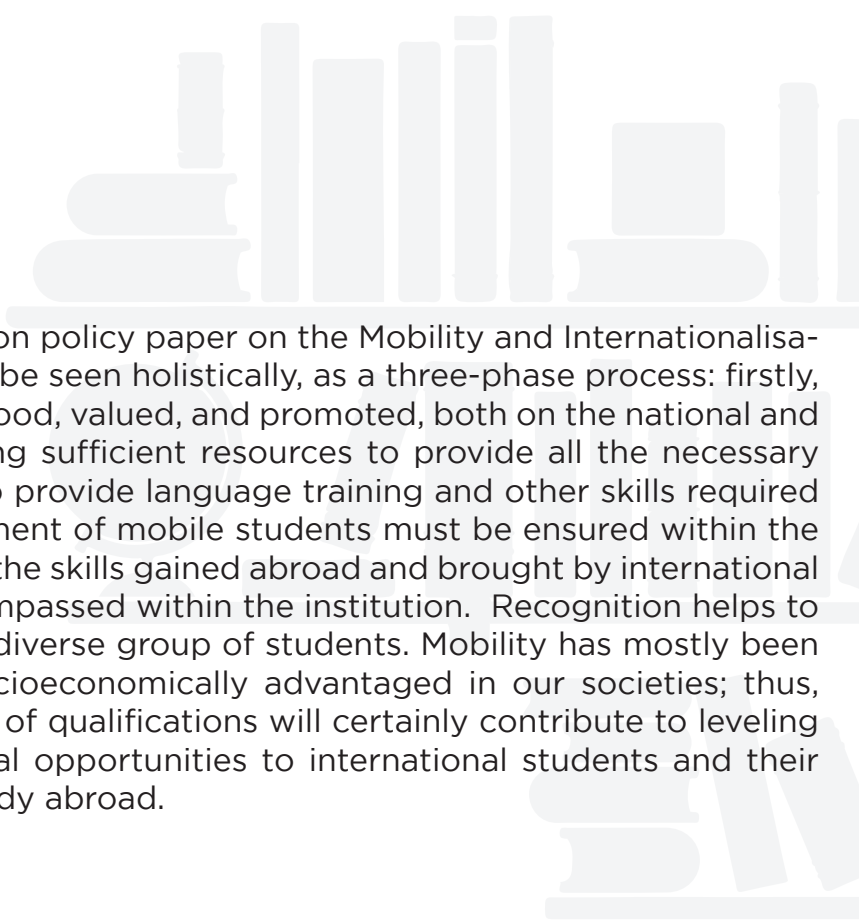
Such exchanges or best practice are more likely to happen when recognition schemes are in place to ensure that the learning experience in one institution is comparable or equal to the learning experience in another. Student mobility, among others, may include the pursuance of a higher education learning opportunity, exchange programmes, and research.

Academic mobility or mobility of students and staff suffers from cultural, family, socio-economical, and academic barriers. The recognition of education qualifications strives to remove these barriers and encourage the mobility of students and staff.

Mobile students can be categorised into perhaps, three distinct groups;

1. those who move freely or willingly on their own accord for purposes such as further studies or research purposes
2. those who move based on academic exchange programmes at the institutional, faculty or national levels
3. those who move due to conflicts or war in their home countries

For any of these groups of students, it is critical to assist them in reaching their academic goals through establishing a system that acknowledges their past learning experiences and qualifications in order to allow them to continue their academic pursuits without added challenges or barriers.



According to the European Students' Union policy paper on the Mobility and Internationalisation of Higher education, mobility should be seen holistically, as a three-phase process: firstly, the purpose of mobility has to be understood, valued, and promoted, both on the national and institutional levels. This includes allocating sufficient resources to provide all the necessary information for the students. Secondly, to provide language training and other skills required by students. The integration and involvement of mobile students must be ensured within the higher education community, and thirdly, the skills gained abroad and brought by international students should be recognised and encompassed within the institution. Recognition helps to realise the right to be mobile for a more diverse group of students. Mobility has mostly been reserved as a privilege for the more socioeconomically advantaged in our societies; thus, solely for a select few. Better recognition of qualifications will certainly contribute to leveling the playing field by providing more equal opportunities to international students and their aspiration to receive scholarships and study abroad.

3.4 What has been done so far?

While regional economic integration in the areas of trade, finance and investment have been established, the process of regional harmonisation in higher education is now picking up gradually, except for the Bologna Process in Europe which has been an example to other regions. However, other regions like Africa are making gradual progress in harmonising their educational systems even though this has been developing at a somewhat slower pace. Considering what has been done and looking at the current progress, there still exists that gap for broader engagement in pressing home the demands for global action on harmonising best practices in education.

Currently, the following regional conventions are applicable:

1. Addis Ababa Convention on the Recognition of Qualifications in Higher education - Africa
2. Asia-Pacific Regional Convention on the Recognition of Qualifications in Higher education
3. Convention on the Recognition of Studies, Diplomas, and Degrees in Higher education in the Arab States
4. Convention on the Recognition of Qualifications concerning Higher education in the European Region
5. Regional Convention on the Recognition of Studies, Diplomas, and Degrees in Higher education in Latin America and the Caribbean
6. Mediterranean Region - Inter-Regional Recognition Convention



With the adoption of the Global convention on Higher education, there is increased hope for students and academic institutions to benefit from diverse opportunities offered in other countries. The convention will provide an opportunity to establish and strengthen inter-regional mobility and recognition of higher education qualifications.

The regional conventions provide better possibilities for global recognition. Even though some countries are yet to fully endorse some regional conventions, the Global Recognition Convention could be an opportunity, through which we can re-echo the need for such conventions and to provide further information sharing on why countries should sign on to these regional conventions and eventually the Global Recognition Convention. The All-Africa Students Union, European Students Union, Commonwealth Student Association and OCLAE are joining forces to engage in a student-led Global Ratification Campaign for the Global convention on the Recognition of Qualifications in Higher education. We do believe that our collective voices will make a difference when it comes to harmonising educational system globally.

4.0 AASU, ESU, CSA AND OCLAE'S COMMITMENT TO MOBILITY OF STUDENTS AND ACADEMICS

Student organisations like ours play a key role in the democratisation of education and the enhancement of learning experiences. We strive to construct mechanisms for our members to work collectively, not only to support the development of individual capacity-building but also to help students in developing the skills to work collaboratively with their peers. In past times, student unions, like the All-Africa Students Union (AASU), were set up to primarily fight against oppressive governments and to bring an end to tyrannical rule. Student unions have proven to be committed to diverse initiatives for a better world and continue to do the same now, with revised and more contemporary approaches.

Today, more than ever, the work of student unions is required to salvage the interests of academic institutions, policymakers, learners, and all other stakeholders in ensuring a broader commitment to the Global convention on the Recognition of Higher Education Qualifications. We believe that, bringing our perspectives to the table, and adding our voice to the Global Ratification Campaign will contribute to speeding up the ratification processes. The following paragraphs highlight our organisations' commitment to the mobility of students and academics, based on our previous works.

4.1 All-Africa Students Union (AASU)

The All-Africa Students Union has been the student voice in two (2) key initiatives of the African Union in partnership with the European Union, aimed at harmonising the education ecosystem in Africa. These initiatives include the Tuning Africa Project and the HAQAA initiative.

- **TUNING AFRICA PROJECT:** The Tuning Africa Pilot Project is implemented in the framework of the Joint Africa-EU Strategy - it is a concrete deliverable of the 2014-2017 Roadmap of the 2014 EU-AU Heads of State and Government Summit. The general objective of the project is to contribute to and support the harmonisation of higher education programmes and the creation of a revitalised, distinctive, attractive, and globally competitive African higher education space, through enhanced intra-African collaboration.
- **HAQAA INITIATIVE:** The HAQAA (Harmonisation of African Higher Education Quality Assurance and Accreditation) Initiative, funded by the European Union, in partnership with the African Union, focuses on the development of a harmonised quality assurance and accreditation system at an institutional level, national, regional and Pan-African continental level. This has included the production of the African Standards and Guidelines for Quality Assurance in Higher education (ASGQA). This reference document provides a common language by which quality in higher education is assessed, and quality procedures are conducted in higher education in Africa.

It could also be useful to note that AASU has also been represented as the student voice in the African Union's Pan African Quality Assurance and Accreditation framework. These key initiatives are geared towards the harmonisation of education in the African region. In all these, the union has shown great commitment and represented the African student voice as it should. AASU further shows its commitment to the mobility of students and academics through its working group on Migration and Mobility as well as the working group on Education and Students Rights.

4.2 European Students Union (ESU)

The European Students' Union (ESU) is the umbrella organisation of 46 National Unions of Students (NUS) from 40 countries. ESU aims to represent and promote the educational, social, economic, and cultural interests of students at the European level towards all relevant bodies and in particular, the European Union, Bologna Follow Up Group, Council of Europe, and UNESCO. Through its members, ESU represents almost 20 million students in Europe.

The European Students' Union continues to be an instrumental partner in the design, review, and implementation of the Erasmus + programme which supports millions of students from around the world. Apart from this, the Union has also shown its commitment to support non-discrimination of non-EU/EEA student and academic wanting to access European higher education and mobility programmes through the following ways:

- ESU's policy on Quality of Higher education defines the organisation's collective position and basis for advocacy of ESU's representatives on matters related to the quality assurance of higher education, including within recognition processes. Primarily, ESU advocates for recognition of prior learning that not only includes formal education qualifications, but also non-formal education and informal learning. The provision of detailed information on learning experiences is crucial to facilitate efficient recognition, but as important is the training of staff reviewing foreign or non-traditional learning. Mutual trust is essential in recognition procedures and built through transparent internal and external quality assurance (QA) of the higher education institutions or ENIC-NARIC agencies responsible for recognition. ESU also supports the training of student representatives to be involved in QA procedures. Through the aforementioned approaches, ESU believes recognition systems can open the possibility for dynamic learning (through micro-credentials) and autonomic recognition of comparable international qualifications without additional bureaucratic procedures.

- ESU has also published a Policy Paper on Mobility and Internationalisation of Higher education. The paper highlights that Barriers such as the full recognition of degrees, qualifications, and credits completed abroad continue to affect mobility. For free movement and mobility to benefit everyone and the internationalisation of higher education institutions, barriers to recognition must be dismantled. Higher education institutions should ensure students a fair recognition process, respecting the learning agreements made and providing guidance and support in the process of selecting a study destination and programme, as well as during the period the student spends abroad. The recognition of foreign diplomas and qualifications from within the EHEA as well as from non-EHEA countries plays a central role in facilitating access

to the second and third cycles. Countries within EHEA should work towards coherent and regulated procedures for recognition of foreign diplomas and professions free of charge and provide transparent information about the recognition process and decision-making within it. A procedure for appealing the decision must be in place.

- ESU oversees the EHEA's commitment to national legislation and implementation of procedures complementary to the LRC through its participation in Thematic Peer Group B of the Bologna-Follow-Up-Group. The objective of the Peer Group is to provide a space for EHEA members and partners to share experience and expertise in the field of recognition, offering to give and receive peer support on the topics of interest particularly: achieving automatic recognition; recognition of alternative pathways; qualifications held by refugees; and optimising the potential of digital technology for the recognition agenda.

- In order to continue enhancing the capacity of the organisation with other partners, ESU was part of the Erasmus + funded LIREQA project (2016-2019). The goals of this project were to align institutional recognition with principles of the LRC and to foster cooperation with educational institutions, quality assurance agencies and national ENIC/NARIC centres. The project focused on enhancing the European dimension in recognition through policy development, benchmarking, best practices, cooperation between members of the network partners in the field of recognition as well as coherence and interactivity with other partners and networks in related fields.

- ESU continued building its capacity within the project consortium for Erasmus + funded project REACT (2018-2020) . The overall goal of the project was to enhance the mobility, employability and access to further studies for refugees, displaced persons and persons in a refugee-like situation – including those without official documentation of their educational background. The project developed a common methodological approach to the recognition of refugees' qualifications and then proceeded to test this toolkit in major refugee-receiving countries and in cooperation with higher education institutions. The project contributes through a bottom-up approach, to establish a more efficient and consistent approach to the recognition of refugees' qualifications in Europe.

- Since 2016, ESU has also led the Together Moving Forward (TMF) project, aimed at building positive refugee-host interactions across Europe. TMF provides grants to support projects led by refugee and non-refugee student organisations across Europe working on the inclusion of young refugees in education and society. Student-led initiatives can and have shown a path to promote inclusive and open societies, to create societal and political change, all this while demonstrating the strength and true value of student and citizens' social engagement and entrepreneurship.

- BWSE (automatic recognition): ESU is also responsible for the Bologna With Students' Eyes (BWSE) publication. BWSE is put together through the collection of data (survey responses) from ESU's membership of NUSes that relays information and evaluation of national governments' agreements within the Bologna Process based on the implementation of these agreements within the national and institutional contexts. With respect to recognition, in a considerable number of countries within the EHEA, student representatives do not consider recognition procedures to be transparent and non-discriminatory. The complexity of the process is one of the main barriers, along with the lack of well-developed recognition

procedures for credits earned outside of the EU/ Erasmus mobility experiences.

Based on this experience, it is evident that the ratification and implementation of the Global Recognition requires bottom-up strategies for implementation with the help of proactive trans-continental collaboration between higher education institutions and recognition authorities.

4.3 Latin American and Caribbean Continental Organization of Students (OCLAE)

OCLAE has played a significant role in promoting actions for the reform and democratisation of education, the eradication of illiteracy, the development of the strongest unity and bonds of solidarity among the students of the continent, for the conquest and defense of their legitimate rights and claims, against the deforming foreign penetration in higher education institutions. With a presence in 23 countries in Latin America and the Caribbean through its almost 40-member organisation, OCLAE promotes an intense mobilization against neoliberal policies and external indebtedness that affect the region and its repercussions on the aggravation of social ills in the field of education and culture. Likewise, it is the standard-bearer of the student's historical commitment to the aspirations of national liberation and independence of the peoples and the ideals of peace, in its broadest sense, of all progressive humanity.

4.4 Commonwealth Students Association

The Virtual University for Small States of the Commonwealth (VUSSC), an initiative of Commonwealth of Learning (COL), is a network for small states, consisting of 31 small states, which is a tool for education ministries and institutes to collaborate with one another to develop content and build capacity in higher education institutes in these countries. The VUSSC is made up for about two thirds of Commonwealth countries across all regions with the aim of benefitting millions of students.

In 2007, members of VUSSC made a proposal to establish a framework for recognition of qualifications that subsequently gave rise to the Transnational Qualifications Framework (TQF). The TQF was not designed to replace existing qualifications in small states but a link between systems across nations. The framework was developed to support the building of courses, standardized recognition of the courses across nations and comparability, building a platform for the transfer of courses and qualification among member countries and enabling the cross border mobility of learners and employees in a seamless.

The TQF has been referenced against Regional and National Qualifications Frameworks (RQFs) in small states. Some of these frameworks include the CARICOM QF, Pacific QF, Southern African Development Community QF, European QF and the ASEAN QF.

As a platform that encourages lifelong learning, the TQF includes basic adult education, technical and vocational education and training and higher education, which includes ten levels of qualifications ranging from certifications to Doctoral Degrees. One of the challenges of students in small states is that despite a breadth of experience in specific fields, students

and may not possess formally recognized or conventional qualifications, putting them at a significant disadvantage in terms of mobility and access.

The TQF encompasses the recognition of prior learning (RPL) for individuals without former formal qualifications and assesses and recognizes individual competencies acquired through formal or non-formal training or through work and life experiences. This significantly removes barrier to access and mobility where individuals do not have to face unnecessary expenses, time and effort to acquire additional training.

Some of the expected outcomes of the TQF are as follows:

1. Developing a mobile and flexible workforce in small states;
2. Easier interpretation of qualification across member states;
3. Accurate match between the demand and supply for skills, knowledge and competencies;
4. Enable employers to interpret and understand standardly recognized qualifications from individuals across the states;
5. Transfer of credits between Higher Education Institutions;
6. Greater learning opportunities and outcomes;
7. Increased choices of courses and programmes in Commonwealth small states
8. Developing of a transparent framework that promotes lifelong learning



5.0 OVERVIEW OF THE GLOBAL CONVENTION ON THE RECOGNITION OF HIGHER EDUCATION QUALIFICATIONS

Have you ever had a challenge, or known someone who has had a challenge to continue education in another country because their prior qualifications are not “accepted”? Imagine a world where students can conveniently move around the world and pursue their studies with very little or no hurdles. Imagine a world where people can migrate to another country and continue their educational pursuits without having to deal with substantial obstacles.

International efforts towards better recognition for educational qualifications started in the 70s and 80s of the past century. From then till now, substantial progress has been made to design and implement academic recognition systems, not only at the regional level but also at the global level.

Millions of students travel away from their home countries to study abroad, even though for many others this is not possible due to various reasons.

The Global convention seeks to eliminate some of these challenges by streamlining recognition systems at the global level. It will undoubtedly change the face of higher education and likely lead to an increase in enrollment of marginalized student groups currently underrepresented in the higher education landscape.

The Global convention is focused on further building and enhancing coordination, revisions, and achievements of the regional recognition conventions. The objectives of this Convention are to:

- 1** Promote and strengthen international cooperation in higher education;
- 2** Support interregional initiatives, policies and innovations for international cooperation in higher education;
- 3** Facilitate global mobility and the achievement of merit in higher education for the mutual benefit of qualification holders, higher-education institutions, employers, and any other stakeholders of the States Parties to this Convention, while understanding and respecting the diversity of the States Parties' higher-education systems;
- 4** Provide an inclusive global framework for the fair, transparent, consistent, coherent, timely and reliable recognition of qualifications concerning higher education;
- 5** Respect, uphold and protect the autonomy and diversity of higher education institutions and systems;
- 6** Foster trust and confidence in the quality and reliability of qualifications through, among other things, the promotion of integrity and ethical practices;
- 7** Promote a culture of quality assurance in higher education institutions and systems, and develop the capacities necessary for ensuring reliability, consistency, and complementarity in quality assurance, in qualifications frameworks and the recognition of qualifications to support international mobility;

- 8** Promote the development, collection, and sharing of accessible, up-to-date, reliable, transparent and relevant information and the dissemination of best practices among stakeholders, State Parties and regions;
- 9** Promote, through the recognition of qualifications, inclusive and equitable access to quality higher education and support lifelong learning opportunities for all, including refugees and displaced persons;
- 10** Foster globally the optimal use of human and educational resources to promote education for sustainable development, and contribute to structural, economic, technological, cultural, democratic, and social development for all societies.

As for the Global Recognition Convention, only a few of the respondents knew about the topic before the survey, hinting at a disparity between the awareness between regional and global initiatives. The respondents stated they were eager to get more information but were divided on the potential impact of the convention – a few also mentioned it would notably affect their work as a student organisation, while others answered it would probably have no impact on them. Respondents from Europe suggested that the two ways in which it could have an effect are easier procedures for recognition of non-EHEA students, and a possibility to better inform the organization's constituency on the quality of qualifications abroad. Furthermore, about 80% of respondents think that the convention will fundamentally change education. The expected changes include raising awareness of the problem, harmonization of education, correct injustices in the recognition of diplomas coming from outside EHEA and less administrative barriers. Besides that, there is also an intercultural element, as the respondents mention possible benefits from competing ideologies and making education more international.

6.0 EXISTING FRAMEWORKS

Before the global convention was adopted by UNESCO, countries have been engaged in regional efforts to facilitate transnational recognition. It is important to note that the Global convention does not come to nullify these regional conventions but rather to strengthen them and make them more effective and cohesive, both at the regional and global level.

Information sharing among regions will be key to the effectiveness of the global convention and its immediate ratification globally. At the regional levels, peer learning approaches can be implemented to help with signing on countries to the applicable recognition conventions. This means that countries that are not ready to sign on, should be provided with technical or financial assistance to be at par with other countries that may be advanced in their efforts to harmonise their qualification systems.

This section of the report highlights the recognition or harmonisation mechanisms that are applicable in each region.

Africa



Beginning in 2018 with the first ratification by Togo, other states that have ratified the convention to date are Burkina Faso, Congo, Djibouti, Gambia, Guinea, Liberia, Mauritius, Mauritania, Senegal, Seychelles, South Africa, and the Holy See. The Convention establishes a legal framework for the fair and transparent evaluation of higher education qualifications in the African region to facilitate inter-university cooperation and exchange through the mobility of students, researchers, and faculty. The Convention creates a binding agreement around the norms and standards for formal procedures, recognising foreign higher education qualifications and those giving access to higher education institutions in Africa.

Europe



The possibility of studying in other European countries has been one of the initial goals of the European integration process since the establishment of the Council of Europe in 1949. During the second half of the 20th century, a number of international pacts and agreements were signed e.g.: right to education (European Convention on Human Rights - 1950, Art. 2),

recognition of secondary school leaving certificates as the basis for admission to studies in the Member States (European Convention on the Equivalence of Diplomas leading to Admission to Universities - 1953), recognition of diplomas and certificates issued by universities (European Convention on the Academic Recognition of University Qualifications - 1959) or the recognition of courses and examinations completed abroad by the primary higher education institutions. (European Convention on the General Equivalence of Periods of University Study - 1990)

In parallel to the process of establishing international conventions in the European arena, the academic community also supported the direction of changes in higher education and the facilitation of the internationalization process. On September 18, 1988 in Bologna, on the 900th anniversary of the establishment of the oldest university in Europe, 388 Rectors of European universities signed the Bologna Charter "Magna Charta Universitatum". For the first time, the charter includes the obligation of European countries to unify the system of assessment and education based on two-cycle studies.

The Convention on the Recognition of Qualifications concerning Higher education in the European Region was developed by the Council of Europe and UNESCO, and adopted by national representatives on April 11th 1997. Most European countries have since ratified this Council of Europe/ UNESCO Convention, usually referred to as the Lisbon Convention. The foundations for establishing the convention were to renew the previous provisions, resulting from the large scale of changes that took place in higher education in Europe, but also due to the significant diversity of systems within individual countries and at the international level. Seeking for the answer to the previous commitments and the ongoing transformation of the higher education systems The Bologna Declaration, signed on June 19, 1999 by 29 ministers of higher education, started the process of unification and consolidation of the European Higher education Area (EHEA). Over the course of its twenty-year history, the Bologna Process has pursued a shared vision of the shape of the Pan-European higher education system in 48 countries holding cultural and political differences. The main fields on which the Bologna

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Declaration is focused are as following:

- introducing a system of transparent and comparable grades through the implementation of the Diploma Supplement,

- adopting an education system based on two / three levels of education,
- widespread use of the credit points system (ie ECTS - European Credit Transfer System),
- promoting the mobility of students, academic teachers, scientists and administrative staff,
- promotion of European cooperation in the field of increasing the quality level of higher education,
- promoting the European dimension of higher education, particularly in the areas of professional development, mobility and integrated curricula, training and research.

Every two or three years there are Ministerial Conferences organised, gathering the authorities from EHEA countries in order to assess the progress made within the EHEA and to decide on the new steps to be taken.

Through the adoption of the EHEA Berlin Communiqué in 2003 (Berlin communiqué, 2003) Qualification Frameworks (QF) have been on the Bologna Process agenda. Qualification frameworks are a tool to strengthen the comparability of degrees and create trust between institutions nationally and internationally. Over the past 17 years, the majority of the EHEA countries have developed NQFs in compliance with the European Qualifications Framework (EQF). Two years ago, in Paris, ministers once again committed themselves to elaborating National Frameworks for Qualifications compatible with the overarching framework for qualifications in the EHEA, EQF. Despite the implementation of NQFs in most EHEA countries, students are still facing difficulties getting their qualification recognised.

Learning Outcomes as a description of what learners are expected to know, be able to do and understand, at the end of a learning sequence are playing an increasingly important role in enhancing the quality of education and training in Europe. It is vital that programmes are well designed with clear intended Learning Outcomes, which are easily understandable and transparent for applicants, students, teachers and the assessors. Currently, learners are not well aware of the NQF in many countries. Hence, raised awareness amongst students would improve their understanding of the educational landscape, nevertheless, it is not necessarily the goal that all students can state the EQF level of their degree. Students should be well informed about the intended Learning Outcomes of their programme, and of where they can find more detailed information if need be, in order to fully use the potential of the System.

In order to implement the Lisbon Recognition Convention and develop the frameworks and practices for recognition of qualification the European Network of Information Centres (ENIC) were established as a joint initiative of UNESCO and the Council of Europe. The close cooperation with National Academic Recognition Information Centres (NARIC) focuses on general provision of information on the recognition of foreign qualifications of all kinds, foreign and domestic education systems and opportunities of studying abroad.

- 2012 Council Recommendation on Recognition of Prior Learning
- European Qualifications Passport for Refugees
- External quality assurance based on the tools of the Bologna Process: ESGs and EQF of recognition and validation authorities

Buenos Aires Recognition Convention

Picture: UNESCO



The Regional Convention for the Recognition of Studies, Degrees, and Diplomas of Higher education in Latin America and the Caribbean, 2019 Buenos Aires, seeks to advance and boost academic mobility, to increase access to education, human right, and the public good, taking into consideration the great diversity of the region and its educational systems. In its role as Secretariat for the Regional Committee on the Buenos Aires Convention, UNESCO-IESALC supports the ratification and implementation of the Convention, through sensitisation and capacity-building, to promote cooperation between the countries of Latin America and the Caribbean.

In Latin America and the Caribbean, the Regional Convention was signed on July 19, 1974, in Mexico City, and ratified by 11 countries in the region. In 2015, UNESCO Member States agreed to update and amend the Convention at the International Conference of States held in Buenos Aires, Republic of Argentina, in July 2019, when 23 Member States adopted a new Convention.



7.0 WHAT DOES THE GLOBAL CONVENTION ON THE RECOGNITION OF HIGHER EDUCATION QUALIFICATIONS MEAN FOR OTHER SECTORS OR AREAS?

In line with the **Education 2030 Agenda**, the **global convention** also aims to improve the quality of higher education institutions and enhance international cooperation in higher education. As student unions, we are very much interested in the impact it will have on all other sectors that contribute to a better world.

- Higher education

Enhancing the delivery and accessibility of higher education is the primary concern of the global convention. A prerequisite for further growth in international student mobility is better comparability across education systems and transferability of degrees and qualifications.

Even though some students study abroad as the first step in a process that leads to permanent migration, a large majority of internationally mobile students eventually return home or end up working in a third country. When students go through diverse challenges to enroll in a foreign higher education institution, they should be confident that the degree they have attained can be applied in any other country. Before the global convention, countries in one region had no obligation to acknowledge or recognise a qualification from another region. Also, the convention seeks to address issues related to the delivery of quality education.

The Convention will furthermore help migrants to access higher education in their new home countries, since it obliges signatory States to put in place mechanisms to facilitate the recognition of refugees' qualifications, even for those who cannot provide any documentary evidence of their qualifications.

- Protecting/Strengthening the rights of International Students

As highlighted earlier, the convention has been implemented in harmony with the existing regional conventions. It is expected to provide the over 2.5 million students who study outside their home region with a legal right to have their qualifications assessed for admission to further study or be employed in another country. Whereas the regional conventions only cover mobility between the countries within those regions, the global convention paves the way for the increased mobility between regions and continents. It also secures other rights for international students which include:

- The right to have foreign qualifications assessed in a fair, non-discriminatory, and transparent manner by competent national authorities. It is important to note that recognition of foreign qualifications will not in itself be guaranteed. Still, the holder will know that he or she will be granted a right to an assessment of their qualifications based on fair, transparent and non-discriminatory criteria.
- Recognition must be given unless the recognising authority can demonstrate a substantial difference between the foreign qualification and qualifications for the country where the recognition is sought.
- Procedures must be put in place for the recognition of qualifications for individuals with insufficient or unverifiable documentation, including refugees and displaced persons.
- Signatory States are also required to put in place robust and ethical quality assurance systems for higher education institutions.

- Skills sets and competencies

The global convention provides an opportunity for individuals to acquire relevant skills and competencies from institutions of learning that they would not have ordinarily been able to acquire from their own countries. The global convention would also contribute to increased teaching and staff mobility, leading to increased internationalization of HEIs. This will accelerate the global outlook of teaching and learning by impacting individual skills developments through a more diverse approach to higher education.

There are many ways to determine the level of skills and their value for employers during the recruitment process - the most widespread being the certificate achieved from formal education or a training system, such as an apprenticeship certificate, diploma, or academic degree. The global recognition provides an opportunity for the proliferation of diverse skills and competencies.

- Brain Circulation

The global convention should include measures to prevent brain drain. This should specifically target the low-income countries that ratify the document. Brain circulation is explained as the movement of skilled individuals from one country to another. The global convention provides support for the recognition of education anywhere. Hence, a qualification obtained in one country could be compared to a qualification obtained elsewhere. This will likely increase the interest of persons to study or to pursue job opportunities in other countries. In the long run, there will be a continual movement of and international and highly skilled labour force around the world.

- Global Trade

Considering the integration of major economies or markets at the regional level which fosters intra-regional trade, there now exists an opportunity for persons to move from their country to work in other countries with little or no challenges. For example, the African Continental Free Trade Area provides an opportunity for skill mobility. However, the recognition of qualifications may be a challenge in such situations. With the introduction of the Global Recognition Convention, there is an opportunity for learners to acquire skills that could be applicable in other parts of the world.

- Intercultural exchanges

As people move around to study, teach, or to research, they will bring along their distinct cultures and share such with citizens of the host country. This will provide an opportunity for other nationals to learn about cultures that they would not have ordinarily known about. It will be expected of universities, States, or institutions to consider ways of leveraging on this opportunity to create more culturally sensitive campus communities. Intercultural exchanges facilitated by the recognition will likely happen through not only a diverse student population but also through a diverse teacher and researcher workforce.

European respondents are quite optimistic about the potential effects of global recognition of qualifications. Only a few do not believe in benefits global trade, while the others hope for higher availability of global specialists and more exchange programs that could foster international exchange. Regarding higher education itself, the impacts could range from easier mobility, less administration barriers to harmonization of higher education systems. On

the other hand, one participant mentions their fear of an emphasized brain drain caused by the increased one-way mobility. Others, however, are hoping for a stronger two-way mobility, i.e. a brain circulation. 8 out of 9 also believe in an impact on the recognition of students rights. As possible effects, they mention a standardization of student rights globally, more awareness and focus on international student rights or stronger voice of students from small and less developed countries. Besides that, 8 out of 9 estimate similar effects on the state of skills and competencies, standardization across regions, easier recognition and development of intercultural skills. Last but not least, all respondents believe that the global recognition convention could foster intercultural exchanges. Among possible outcomes they mention forming of a global culture, higher frequency of exchanges, diversification of HEIs, accessibility of exchanges and easier organization of academic mobility.

Asian respondents think this convention will change education fundamentally, backing up with several reasons. According to the respondents, it will increase the opportunities for students and promote the right of individuals to have their higher education qualifications evaluated through fair, transparent and non-discriminatory manners. Students will be able to better choose a career they actually like. It will help educational institutions to stabilize further. It will also play a role in lessening discrimination towards degree holders from developing countries. Democratising global education will be of much benefit especially during the time of a pandemic. Allowing mobility of students and the flexibility of the courses they wish to pursue could aid in a larger picture of human resources development, global mind-sets, and promote international peace & cultural awareness as a whole in the long run. This mentality will also act as a guiding tool for educators to deliver better in classrooms. On the contrary, some of the respondents expressed despair because they think similar initiatives have been taken before but failed. If the convention is not ratified by all countries, students in many countries will lack the benefits of this convention.





PHOTOGRAPH BY GETTY IMAGES/VETTA

8.0 KEY RECOMMENDATIONS & THE WAY FORWARD

The following recommendations are based on discussions with national student unions and other stakeholders geared towards further engagements in the implementation of the Global Recognition Convention.

- The experiences of learners, teachers, and researchers should be taken into critical consideration in the implementation, monitoring, and evaluation of the processes highlighted under the convention;
- Student unions should be considered as critical stakeholders in the implementation of the Global Recognition Convention. As an equal member of the academic community, they have the potential to advance the interests of the convention;
- There is a need to have a student-led global ratification campaign. Having a worldwide solidarity campaign of all global, regional and national student unions would be very critical to increase the pressure on national authorities to ratify the convention.
- There should be capacity building programmes for student organisations to better understand the convention and how it is relevant to their work.
- Student unions should be engaged by their national accreditation or recognition boards, especially in the dissemination of relevant information in support of international students, and even with other student unions from different regions;
- Student unions can support efforts to ensure that governments and accreditation entities are going by the tenets as stated in the convention.